

The Poetry Quartet: Source Poems of RICD

Note: this quartet of poetry was written over the course of about a year and a half. At first, I was unaware the poems were related, until I wrote the final poem Raison d'Etre, and realized all four were describing different aspects of the same idea, and formed a quartet of poems about survival. To understand the math in them which became RICD, please see the "Source Translation Ledger" below, which places the math in the poems directly beneath the corresponding lines.

The Next Time

The next time we

go stumbling through

bright woods

in search of darkness,

the next time we

hold our breath

and shear our

paper wings off,

the next time we trust

the tower guard

with the unblinking eye,

the next time

we believe anything

taught in a world so
fraught it's impossible
to emerge from;
the next time we brave
this wilderness
with innocence,
unquestioning belief
in the pure motives
of our narrative,
the next time
we mistake our
stumble for our
arrival, the next rescue
will be ours:
in the tears that bind us
to kindness
we'll flounder in
the big bright darkness,
our bright eyes

shining wet

and full of stars.

Rumination

(It's like scratching an itch
to go down into that darkness).
A prying scratch, prising
the light from your eyes,
dimming your grin, cracking your teeth,
weathering them to old porcelain.
Some ancient addiction, perhaps,
a rage at being born, at the windmilling
futility of it all.
It's easy to do, too,
because pain we may presume a greater gift than joy
against the ravages of time and space
as it's less fleeting;
love might be the point, but
like a precious gem it's mined near through
and the marketplace is flooded with fakes.
And the ones who hate—
the ones who spend their every waking
moment burning to lash out at any who scrape
the barest happiness out of this circumstance
in order to remind them all the time
how very miserable they really
must be at the mess we've made
of our whole family tree—
well they make life memorable, too.
(Yes, it gets easy after a while
scratching the itch
that pulls us down, down, beneath the skin).

You Get to an Age

When you think nothing human
can surprise. That's why I unblocked you, the dead rapist;
such magnanimity, such largesse
of spirit, it swells my chest, presses
against my lungs, flattening speech, flattening breath,
choking me to death, along with those awful
tears that morning I discovered you'd died,
just months after I told you I longed to see you
swinging at the end of your rope.

I'm here because you can still surprise.
Not your political takes, whether those I disagree with,
on the basis of my own humanity (the rhetorical lens
through which you viewed life was misogyny),
or those I agree with, because I am also a struggling teacher,
a struggling writer, just
struggling, saddled with the same
impostor syndrome that you had,
only mine's more learned than earned--
one of the many problems you had with me,
wasn't it? (I was a better version of you
in your mind, and to make matters worse, a woman).

But no. What surprised me is how you managed
to piss me off from beyond the grave.
You were homeless before you died;
even your family didn't have the heart anymore
to help you. – What can I say? What drove them away?
In the end, was it your alcoholism, which really was just your medicine
to forget who you were, for even a second?
Something like that– something that caused *them* trouble–
something so visibly out of place in the carefully-curated
museum to middle-class values that was their ranch-style home:
I could imagine *that* finally doing the trick.
Not all the women raped, stalked, strangled in the world
would be enough to make your mother stop smothering
you with her suffocating bond, but you getting too
drunk at family dinner;

well, that's another matter altogether.

What pissed me off is the way you talked
of your life. "As a homeless man with PTSD..."
I suppose van der Kolk, when tallying up the score, spoke
in his book with some sympathy about men like you,
such as the man who couldn't stop shaking after he raped and murdered
a woman during wartime.
Poor guy, I couldn't help but think,
haunted by her ghost, crying out night after night *why did you do it*.
Maybe some wounds we should have to live with.

When I was nineteen, my childhood friend and I
got high with a pair of drug dealers.
I was getting over a relationship with another abuser
of women, this one who liked to strangle, punch, use the same words
his father had used for him when he did the same,
useless, what's the point of you.
I was working full-time after leaving him,
finishing up my degree; he found himself adrift after all the harm
without family to help, a lot like you.
My friend was struggling with addiction, a disease;
I did not know, nor did I know
why we were at that house, just that it started with weed
and progressed to coke, line after line,
and a fight broke out, about, of all things, rape,
which I'd already experienced but couldn't bring myself
to admit, not even to myself.
I played Devil's advocate, arguing I'd rather
be raped than rapist, that even if he
killed you a rapist couldn't touch your soul,
but with that one moment he shattered his own.

They grew angry, telling me, as they gave my friend,
who later almost died, line after line
of the drug that was killing her, that such criminals
should be rounded up, released on an island,
with only each other for company;
I argued that the soul of a rapist is destroyed by his act
worse than he could ever hurt his victim.
They showed us out then, *no harm, no foul*.
Angry faces, fist bump at the door.
I still remember.

I've had plenty of personal chances to reevaluate;

yet the only thing I got wrong was how much of my soul
a man like you could take.
Each injection of venom and each attempt to evade it
left me injured, fragmented, strewn across a psychic landscape
more hostile than anyplace on Earth; the war to end
all wars, every bit of evil man can commit, lives in that land,
and the soul, finding itself stranded, flees to whatever foxhole
it can find, sometimes never to be seen again.
I get back fragments, since then; but rapacious, stubborn,
I won't give in. I'm in search of it all, and more;
I want to get something out of this in the end;
or what was it all for, my friend?

When I discovered you died
I cried, because I loved you,
in the beginning. I used to imagine us living in a little house
across from downtown campus, teaching together,
in the early days we knew each other.
All my abstract understanding — of your envy, your insecurity, your personality
disorder, your mental health struggles, your childhood—
will never make me understand
why you set out to destroy someone who loved you;
(or why you weren't the first man nor the last).
It's as if love is some sort of affront,
some violent act, one which deserves a response in kind.

Who knows. Maybe you did get PTSD
from raping, from stalking, from systematically breaking
me down, watching me cry
in your arms, knowing I *hated* you,
that even up to the day you reached out from the shelter,
all I wanted was you dead.

When I heard you died, I laughed like a maniac.
I laughed all goddamn day and night.
I may be sick as a dog, but here I am, and I'm alive;
10 years later, and which one of us made it?
– Each act shriveled you, didn't it?
You looked like a wizened old man when you died.
Let me go back in time and tell those two young dealers that.
In the end what you take from others you can't get back.

Raison d'Etre

If there was any reason in at all,
all the violence I've experienced,
if somewhere there is a logic
to the universe,
from atom to Adam,
then it is this, in the end,
not rock bottom
but resurrection.

What's clear is the numbness
I've carried since childhood—a shield
against suffering—can happen
to anyone. And it does,
eventually, too, to nearly
everyone, just to some
very slowly what it did to me all at once, same
fading, same dissolution,
but at different speeds—nearly
everyone ends up a ghost.

Whether violence
or the drip-drip-drip erosion
of nothing much happening
it doesn't matter which kills us;
in an age of iterative screens,
a shrine to dissociation in every bedroom
ghosts argue with ghosts
(the spirit of an angry God's
bad joke—we declare Him dead so He decides
to curse such ingrates by engineering lives
so bereft we forget
every second is precious).

In this age, shrieks feel more alive
than sighs; sometimes the hull must breach
for us to sense it, and if there's a reason
I had to repeat
the many violations of my youth
in my thirties, only worse—(make it
more devastating this time,
someone must have chimed in,

some shiftless staff
writer, armchair director)—
—in hindsight, this was it, wasn't it?

—All this was the gift.—

—They've given me many,
my cleverest hunters,
the men who laid careful traps
as if I were a rare deer,
a delicacy necessary
for the men's survival,
as if my cries ringing out
above birds and brook were not
in fact the downstream consequence
of such men's creature comforts;
—I thank those clever hunters,
who gave so much of themselves
to the hunt,
and I thank too what architects
must exist, for their gifts:
a hard-won insight
into how the light dies in others' eyes,
the first time that it went out
in mine.

—But of all their magnificent gifts—the joy
in suffering, the pained burden
of violence—the price of sickness
remains greatest;
because the only way out of a gray plane
of existence—that place of dead space
and pain, of static
interspliced with blood, of towers
of ever-teetering tasks,
of screams that bury us
where we expected paradise,
the only way out, back to the sunlit
patch of promise into which
we were born, is
to nearly die, to be resurrected, to become
that being of light born of one's own ashes;
—but before all that to be

simply Lazarus, to sink
to the floor to kiss it, on our

knees to shake
with laughter, and so to exit
the cold cave of
our embodiment, blind;
–all the old shapes,
those cave shadows, vanish
in one sun-struck blink
of a bleary eye; and
tears fallen, the light
streams in, as we rush to greet
our enemies with a kiss
and then our friends.

Source Translation Ledger

The Poems, With RICD's Mathematics Set Directly Above the Lines It Describes

The Next Time

O_o(t) corrupted by developmental entropic damage while O_p(t) remains comparatively intact -- the baseline condition for most living systems, humans particularly (Definitions 10.5b.2.12-13). Baseline Miscalibration (Definition 10.5b.2.20): destabilizing signal read as calm, restrictive coupling read as protective.

Sonic/Formal Note: Enjambment throughout this poem functions as continuous, valence-neutral momentum -- formally identical whether the trajectory it carries is rushing toward repetition-compulsion or, later, toward escape. Continuity is not inherently positive or negative; it is simply what unforced movement looks like, for better or worse, until something breaks it.

Sonic/Formal Note: Ending the poem's very first line on the bare pronoun "we" establishes the collective identity of the innocents as the baseline condition the poem begins from, before anything else -- setting, action, danger -- has even been introduced.

The next time we

Sonic/Formal Note: "Through" ending the line emphasizes trajectory over location -- this is about passage, movement, direction, not about arriving somewhere named. The woods themselves are almost incidental to the fact of moving through them.

go stumbling through

bright woods

in search of darkness,

a(t), adaptive capacity -- sacrificed pre-maturity rather than developed.

the next time we

hold our breath

and shear our

paper wings off,

X_{i,j}, extraction flux (§8.6a) -- the target/extractor relationship. Baseline Miscalibration: damaging exchange read as rewarding.

Sonic/Formal Note: "Trust," held alone, makes a complete, devastating claim on its own -- this happens the next time we trust, full stop -- before the line continues to specify trust's object (the tower guard). The general vulnerability and the specific betrayal are both present in the same six letters.

the next time we trust

the tower guard

with the unblinking eye,

Captive Official Layer (Definition 10.5b.18.1) -- a corrupted O_o sincerely, not deceptively, believing what it is told.

the next time

we believe anything

Sonic/Formal Note: "So," held alone, reads as a demonstrative -- taught in a world such as this -- a complete descriptive claim about the world's basic character, before the next line reveals it as a degree intensifier instead (so fraught that it's impossible). Both readings describe the same despair from different grammatical angles.

taught in a world so

Sonic/Formal Note: "Impossible," held alone, makes a complete claim -- this world is impossible -- echoing the exact same underlying claim as the previous line's own double meaning (below). The two enjambment-generated readings converge on the identical meaning, a recursive loop where the broken and unbroken versions of the sentence say the same thing twice, from two different angles.

fraught it's impossible

to emerge from;

Repetition-Compulsion Drive (Definition 10.5b.2.18) -- the same cycle recurring without the container recognizing it as a cycle.

Sonic/Formal Note: "Brave" held alone reads as an adjective describing the innocents themselves -- they are brave -- rather than only as a verb awaiting its object (to brave this wilderness). Both readings stand: a stated quality and an action about to be named.

the next time we brave

this wilderness

Sonic/Formal Note: "Innocence" is an auditory near-rhyme to "innocents," the noun for the people themselves -- the quality and the population echoing each other, calling to mind these innocents as ones who will later lead new innocents through the same treacherous landscape.

with innocence,

unquestioning belief

in the pure motives

of our narrative,

the next time

Sonic/Formal Note: This poem repeatedly ends enjambed lines on the bare word "our" (here, and at "and shear our," above) -- the line itself stumbles, incomplete, mirroring the stumbling the poem describes, before each resolves into what "our" belongs to. This cumulative formal stumbling is what makes the eventual, real rescue land as more surprising: the poem's own rhythm has been unsteady the entire time leading up to it.

we mistake our

stumble for our

arrival, the next rescue

Sonic/Formal Note: The turn at "will be ours" is both a formal break and a register shift simultaneously, not two separate surprises coinciding -- a single discontinuity in the active metric producing both effects at once, since the metric governs both the geometric shape of movement (rhythm) and what that movement produces (content). The repetition building of enjambed lines to this point ("the next time we... the next time we...") primes the reader to

expect continuation, making the discontinuity, when it lands, unmistakable as a break in real time.

will be ours:

Search Cessation (Definition 10.5b.2.21) -- ceasing the search for false security is a real, separate precondition, prior to and distinct from what follows. A_{ij} , real network coupling strength -- mutual, reciprocal stabilization. The semi-rigid horizontal matrix (Shaking Bowls' own term) forming through voluntary affiliation (§10.5b.2.17's Horizontal Matrix Attraction).

Sonic/Formal Note: Following the turn, the poem shifts from rushing enjambment to sustained caesura -- no longer a tumbling rhythm, instead savoring each line. This is a different texture from the earlier momentum, matching Ultimate Convergence's own characteristic description elsewhere in this framework: quiet, fluid, frictionless grace.

Sonic/Formal Note: "Bind us" ending the line makes a complete claim on its own -- the tears themselves bind us together -- before "to kindness" specifies what quality that binding delivers. Both readings hold: the shared crying is the bond, and it is specifically a bond toward kindness.

in the tears that bind us

to kindness

Sonic/Formal Note: "in," ending the line before "the big bright darkness" arrives, opens a transitive reading of "flounder" alongside its ordinary intransitive one – not just floundering, but floundering IN a quality or quantity, importing the cosmos—"the big bright darkness" the innocents stand looking upon, in the woods, which are actually dark; standing linked together and looking at the stars becomes a way of importing the starlight to earth, magnified by the liquid curved vectors of the innocents' tearful eyes, causing their eyes to light up the woods as they "flounder in" the cosmos into the matrix being formed, rather than merely enduring it alone.

we'll flounder in

the big bright darkness,

our bright eyes

shining wet

and full of stars.

Note: the implication of the end of the poem is that the innocents break away from the baseline extractive cycle to form a parallel matrix which starves the tower guard of its source of extraction ($X_{\{i,j\}} \rightarrow 0$); and their light is so bright it drowns out the tower guard's tracking beam even before its failure due to lack of resources to extract from to power its mechanical tracking beam — a failure that is its own Hull-breach condition (§10.5a), reached through resource decline (δR) it cannot adapt around, since unlike the innocents' own suppressed but real adaptive capacity ($a(t)$), a fixed mechanism has no adaptive degrees of freedom ($d_A \approx 0$) to fall back on — as any new innocents entering the forest will see the light of the horizontal matrix and head straight for it, avoiding the lure of the tower guard altogether; the poem thus ends on a hopeful beginning of nonviolent negentropic revolution – via "nonparticipation and reorganization" – within an entropic grid.

Rumination

Extraction-Hunger Accumulator (Definition 10.5b.19.1) -- a self-reinforcing reward cycle around extraction, structurally close to addiction.

Sonic/Formal Note: The parenthetical functions as a whisper, both sonically (an aside, quieter than declared speech, the correct register for internal persuasion rather than command) and visually (the parentheses themselves a typographic container-within-a-container, enacting a rogue metamessenger population sitting inside but distinct from the larger operational layer). This device book-ends the poem -- see its second appearance near the poem's close.

(It's like scratching an itch
to go down into that darkness).

Sonic/Formal Note: "A prying scratch, prising / the light from your eyes" -- a single pun carrying the entire high-entropy/medium-entropy coupling dynamic. The high-entropy system prizes the light instrumentally, for what it yields, and that prizing IS the act of prising (extracting) it; the medium-entropy system, receiving the identical act, experiences it as being prized in the other sense -- seen, valued -- which is what makes willing entry into the coupling coherent rather than foolish. One word, two parties, each living a different sense of it at the same moment: Baseline Miscalibration's third class (damaging exchange read as rewarding), executed in real time by the pun itself rather than merely described.

A prying scratch, prising
the light from your eyes,
dimming your grin, cracking your teeth,
weathering them to old porcelain.
Some ancient addiction, perhaps,

Sonic/Formal Note: "A rage at being born" names the founding perturbation (§10.5b.0.0a) directly -- existence itself as the origin event. The poem's larger argument is that mistaking this genesis event for the system's actual direction is the error: believing oneself entropy-seeking by nature, when negentropy-seeking was the real underlying default the whole time.

Sonic/Formal Note: "Windmilling," held alone, reads as the direct object of the rage -- anger at the windmilling itself, the flailing motion -- before the next line reveals it modifying "futility" instead. Both readings persist: rage at being born, and rage at the specific, aimless shape that existence takes.

a rage at being born, at the windmilling
futility of it all.

The medium-entropy system's real vulnerability (Shaking Bowls; Sampling Fidelity Requirement, Definition 10.5b.15.1) -- mistaking a predatory neighbor's momentary stillness for genuine stability.

It's easy to do, too,

Sonic/Formal Note: Pain explicitly preferred over pleasure because it feels less fleeting -- a false-stability preference, entropy mistaken for the more durable, more powerful state when negentropy is what is actually durable. Distinct in kind from Baseline Miscalibration's other

four classes (all misreads of a specific signal's valence or source); this is a comparative misjudgment about which entire regime is the more permanent one.

because pain we may presume a greater gift than joy

against the ravages of time and space

as it's less fleeting;

Sonic/Formal Note: "Point" trails off on a soft nasal ending; "but," opening the very next line, cuts against it with a hard plosive -- the sentence refusing its own claim not only grammatically but sonically, a sharp rebuttal in sound as well as sense.

love might be the point, but

Sonic/Formal Note: "Mined" read alone is a completed state -- it IS mined, already extracted, gone -- before "near through" reveals a nearly-but-not-quite-finished process instead. Both readings hold together: love must be actively sought, like a mining effort, and it is nearly exhausted by relentless extraction, though not yet entirely.

like a precious gem it's mined

Sonic/Formal Note: "Marketplace," held alone, makes a claim prior to and larger than the fakes that follow: genuine, uncommodified love could never be found in a marketplace to begin with, transactional society itself being the deeper problem. "Flooded with fakes" becomes almost redundant once "marketplace" has already been named -- of course it is; nothing real belongs there regardless.

near through, and the marketplace

Sonic/Formal Note: The official layer performing counterfeit versions of a genuine value (love) while the real thing grows scarce -- "flooded with fakes" as the marketplace's own inversion, real value crowded out by its own imitation.

is flooded with fakes.

Sonic/Formal Note: "The ones who hate" are tied to "the mess we've made of our whole family tree" -- generational, developmental origin implied without the word trauma ever being used.

And the ones who hate—

the ones who spend their every

Sonic/Formal Note: "Burning," held alone at the break, suggests their own waking existence is itself burning -- a private hell endured even while outwardly directing hatred at others -- before the line resolves into the more conventional idiom, burning to lash out.

waking moment burning

to lash out at any who scrape

Sonic/Formal Note: "This," left hanging without its referent for one line, briefly opens real doubt about whether the circumstance is what it seems, or whether there's more to it than meets the eye, before "circumstance" closes that ambiguity down.

the barest happiness out of this

Sonic/Formal Note: "All the time" ending the line marks this as an eternal, ongoing project -- not a single act of cruelty but a perpetual attempt to degrade anyone else's search for meaning.

circumstance, to remind them all the time

how very miserable they really

must be at the mess we've made

of our whole family tree—
well they make life memorable, too.

Epistemic Capture (Definition 10.5b.15.3) -- a medium-entropy system coming to believe the entropic, self-deceiving message IS the true message and the only reality, not merely being drawn toward it.

Sonic/Formal Note: This parenthetical closes the poem exactly as it opened it -- true book-ending, with nothing after it to resolve the loop. Between the two appearances the underlying mechanism has escalated from Extraction-Hunger Accumulator to full Epistemic Capture, marking that time has passed within the poem without granting any exit from it. Structurally the opposite of "The Next Time": that poem ends after its resolving discontinuity fires; this one ends before its own has occurred, sitting inside the accumulation phase by design.

(Yes, it gets easy after a while
scratching the itch
that pulls us down, down, beneath the skin).

You Get to an Age

Reconciling paradoxical extremes without forcing a false resolution -- Paradoxical Convergence, medium-entropy direction (Definition 10.5b.0.9b): a container ceasing to punish itself for an entropic spike (registering anger, hatred, grief without the accompanying self-suppression response) allows the spike to dissipate through ordinary relaxation rather than compounding into sustained divergence, drifting the container naturally toward its own already-intact operational calm. This is the real mechanism the poem enacts throughout: holding love and rage toward the same person as two genuinely divergent, simultaneously true states, without collapsing either into a forced single verdict.

When you think nothing human
can surprise. That's why I unblocked you, the dead rapist;
such magnanimity, such largesse
of spirit, it swells my chest, presses

Sonic/Formal Note: "Flattening speech, flattening breath" (repetition) into "choking me to death" (rhyme) with unbroken enjambment running through every line break -- the compounding devices don't describe constriction, they inflict it on the reader directly, charging the Forcing Tax (§10.5b.0.5.1) in real time rather than reporting it. The content is a forced, control-shaped self-intervention (forcing oneself into "magnanimity"); the form makes the reader feel the cost of that forcing.

against my lungs, flattening speech, flattening breath,
choking me to death, along with those awful
tears that morning I discovered you'd died,
just months after I told you I longed to see you
swinging at the end of your rope.

I'm here because you can still surprise.
Not your political takes, whether those I disagree with,
on the basis of my own humanity (the rhetorical lens
through which you viewed life was misogyny),
or those I agree with, because I am also a struggling teacher,
a struggling writer, just
struggling, saddled with the same
impostor syndrome that you had,
only mine's more learned than earned--
one of the many problems you had with me,
wasn't it? (I was a better version of you
in your mind, and to make matters worse, a woman).

But no. What surprised me is how you managed
to piss me off from beyond the grave.

You were homeless before you died;
even your family didn't have the heart anymore
to help you. --What can I say? What drove them away?
In the end, was it your alcoholism, which really was just your medicine
to forget who you were, for even a second?

Something like that--something that caused *them* trouble--
something so visibly out of place in the carefully-curated

*Sonic/Formal Note: "Museum to middle-class values" -- a museum curates appearance, not
lived function, making the family home's actual operating principle legible as performance
rather than substance. This maps precisely onto §10.5b.18.18c, Official-Narrative
Maintenance Is Priority-Ordered Ahead of Adaptive Work: nothing about real violence would
disrupt the family's protective enabling, but a breach of visible decorum would -- form held
sacred, function disposable, the exact inversion of function-before-form.*

museum to middle-class values that was their
ranch-style home: I could imagine *that* finally doing the trick.
Not all the women raped, stalked, strangled in the world
would be enough to make your mother stop smothering
you with her suffocating bond, but you getting too
drunk at family dinner; well, that's another matter altogether.

What pissed me off is the way you talked
of your life. "As a homeless man with PTSD..."

*Sonic/Formal Note: Irony without dishonesty -- the surface voice performs real,
sincere-sounding sympathy for the perpetrator's own documented suffering, trusting the
reader to hold that surface against the actual crime and notice, unassisted, that the sympathy
is misdirected.*

I suppose van der Kolk, when tallying up the score, spoke
in his book with some sympathy about men like you,
such as the man who couldn't stop shaking after he raped and murdered
a woman during wartime.

Poor guy, I couldn't help but think,
haunted by her ghost, crying out night after night *why did you do it*.
Maybe some wounds we should have to live with.

*Repetition-Compulsion Drive (Definition 10.5b.2.18) -- self-attributed dysfunction generating
a bias toward re-engaging the same class of coupling that produced the original disruption.*

When I was nineteen, my childhood friend and I
got high with a pair of drug dealers.

I was getting over a relationship with another abuser
of women, this one who liked to strangle, punch, use the same words

his father had used for him when he did the same,
useless, what's the point of you.
I was working full-time after leaving him,
finishing up my degree; he found himself adrift after all the harm
without family to help, a lot like you.
My friend was struggling with addiction, a disease;
I did not know, nor did I know
why we were at that house, just that it started with weed
and progressed to coke, line after line,
and a fight broke out, about, of all things, rape,
which I'd already experienced but couldn't bring myself
to admit yet, not even to myself.
I played Devil's advocate, arguing I'd rather
be raped than rapist, that even if he
killed you a rapist couldn't touch your soul,
but with that one moment he shattered his own.

They grew angry, telling me, as they gave my friend,
who later almost died, line after line
of the drug that was killing her, that such criminals
should be rounded up, released on an island,
with only each other for company;
I argued that the soul of a rapist is destroyed by his act
worse than he could ever hurt his victim.
They showed us out then, *no harm, no foul.*
Angry faces, fist bump at the door.
I still remember.

Since then, I've had plenty of personal chances to reevaluate;
yet the only thing I got wrong was how much of my soul
a man like you could take.

Self-Corrosion (Definition 10.5b.19.7) -- a closed, high-entropy circuit cannot actually keep what it extracts from another; the attempted extraction itself increases the extractor's own divergence and contracts its own adaptive space, independent of and additional to whatever the extraction did to the target.

Each injection of venom and each attempt to evade it
left me injured, fragmented, strewn across a psychic landscape

Sonic/Formal Note: "The war to end" reads as a complete clause on its own -- this psychic landscape IS the war that needs ending -- before the line continues into the familiar idiom "all wars," folding a private, urgent meaning and a historical cliché into the same six words without choosing between them. Enjambment doing this specific work (double meaning through an unnatural break, not just momentum) recurs constantly throughout this poem.

more hostile than anyplace on Earth; the war to end
all wars, every bit of evil man can commit, lives in that land,
and the soul, finding itself stranded, flees to whatever foxhole
it can find, sometimes never to be seen again.

I get back fragments, since then; but rapacious, stubborn,
I won't give in. I'm in search of it all, and more;
I want to get something out of this in the end;

Sonic/Formal Note: "My friend," addressed directly and bitterly to the rapist, collapses the enemy/friend distinction the same way the ending of "Raison d'Être" does -- not sincere the way genuine intimacy is sincere, closer to the "clever hunters" irony: a term of closeness applied to someone who forfeited any claim to it.

or what was it all for, my friend?

When I discovered you died
I cried, because I loved you,
in the beginning. I used to imagine us living in a little house
across from downtown campus, teaching together,
in the early days we knew each other.

All the abstract understanding--of your envy, your insecurity, your personality
disorder, your mental health struggles, your childhood--
will never make me understand
why you set out to destroy someone who loved you;
(or why you weren't the first man nor the last).

It's as if love is some sort of affront,
some violent act, one which deserves a response in kind.
Who knows. Maybe you *did* get PTSD
from raping, from stalking, from systematically breaking
me down, watching me cry
in your arms, knowing I hated you,
that even up to the day you reached out from the shelter,
all I wanted was you dead.

When I heard you died, I laughed like a maniac.
I laughed all goddamn day and night.

I may be sick as a dog, but here I am, and I'm alive;
10 years later, and which one of us made it?

-Every act shriveled you, didn't it?
You looked like a wizened old man when you died.
Let me go back in time and tell those two young dealers that.

Self-Corrosion (Definition 10.5b.19.7), Proposition 10.5b.19.7.1 (Extraction Is Net-Negative for the Extractor) -- what a closed system takes from another it cannot get back.

In the end what you take from others you can't get back.

Sonic/Formal Note: The entire first stanza is built from confident, complete, caesura-heavy declarations -- short, self-contained assertions -- before the second stanza's enjambment takes over and the texture changes entirely.

Raison d'Être

Ultimate Convergence (Definition 10.5b.0.6) -- dissolution of a rigid container back toward the open, low-entropy baseline.

If there was any reason in at all,
all the violence I've experienced,
if somewhere there is a logic
to the universe,

Sonic/Formal Note: A satisfying near-rhyme (atom/Adam) arriving inside a search for cosmic justification of suffering -- the pleasure of finding clever wordplay is itself evidence the numbness discussed two stanzas later is already operating here, dressed as insight.

from atom to Adam,
then it is this, in the end,
not rock bottom
but resurrection.

Sonic/Formal Note: The thesis of the entire poem, compressed into one paradoxical line. "Clear" is doing two incompatible jobs at once: mechanical, procedural exactness (first this, then this -- clarity as a checklist) standing in for genuine felt understanding, which is entirely absent. This is control mistaken for safety (§10.5b.2.20's fourth Baseline Miscalibration class) turned inward -- the numbness feels like safety because it feels procedurally manageable, not because anything has actually been metabolized. The first stanza's "resurrection" is being quietly undercut here: what looks like arrival at stability is dissociation wearing clarity's clothes. A close cousin of the psychopathy research discussed alongside this poem -- articulate, precise self-description of one's own mechanism is not evidence the mechanism has changed. What's clear is the numbness

I've carried since childhood—a shield
against suffering—can happen
to anyone. And it does,

Sonic/Formal Note: Enjambment lands repeatedly on small, imprecise-quantity words ("nearly," "some") through this stanza, producing a seemingly random chopping of line lengths that alternately slows and speeds the poem -- sonically enacting the very slow-versus-fast collapse distinction the content describes.

eventually, too, to nearly

Sonic/Formal Note: "Just to some" carries a double meaning on "just" -- a moral verdict (fair, deserved) hiding inside a mere quantifier (only some people) -- entropy mistaken for justice, suffering normalized as deserved rather than recognized as arbitrary.

everyone, just to some
very slowly what it did to me all at once, same
fading, same dissolution,

Drift-type versus shock-type classification (Section 9) -- the same real collapse outcome reachable through a slow, homogeneous process or a sudden, discrete one.

Sonic/Formal Note: The second "nearly," ending its line in the same position as the first, shifts function: no longer modifying the population (nearly all people) but modifying the state itself -- everyone ends up nearly a ghost, not fully one.

but at different speeds—nearly
everyone ends up a ghost.

Whether violence

Sonic/Formal Note: "Drip-drip-drip" enacts cumulative small knocks (§10.5b.9f.3); "erosion" itself phonetically performs its own meaning, stress landing hard on the second syllable before trailing off through the soft "-sion," the word fading exactly as it describes fading.

or the drip-drip-drip erosion
of nothing much happening
it doesn't matter which kills us;

Dissociation Load (Definition 10.5b.18.4c) -- restored, original central dependent variable of the earliest FDFM model.

in an age of iterative screens,
a shrine to dissociation in every bedroom

Sonic/Formal Note: "Ghosts argue with ghosts" opens on a spondee (GHOSTS AR-gue, two consecutive stressed syllables) and bookends on two hard-G onsets -- percussive, hollow, an argument with no real content, just two identical stressed things colliding.

ghosts argue with ghosts

Sonic/Formal Note: God recast as an angry, vengeful "engineer" of suffering (engineering lives to punish being declared dead -- a tongue-in-cheek Nietzsche reference) arrives directly after a stanza on humanity's own dissociative self-engineering -- two forms of engineering-away-from-feeling aimed in opposite directions.

(the spirit of an angry God's

bad joke—we declare Him dead so He decides
to curse such ingrates by engineering lives

Sonic/Formal Note: "Lives... forget... precious" form a chain of near-rhyme/eye-rhyme across several lines -- close enough to create rhyme-expectation, not close enough to satisfy it, producing a subtly jarring, off-kilter quality.

so bereft we forget
every second is precious).

Hull Breach (Section 10.5a) -- verbatim term-level survival. Approach Detectability (Definition 10.5a.1) -- noticeable, fast collapse can more reliably lead to reset than slow, undetected collapse.

Sonic/Formal Note: "Shrieks... breach... reason" share a long vowel near-echo (assonance) across three lines, an unsettling almost-rhyme rather than a resolved one.

In this age, shrieks feel more alive
than sighs; sometimes the hull must breach

Sonic/Formal Note: "Reason" sliding into "Repetition" (the math annotation below) through alliteration produces a stuttering r-sound that itself resembles a stuck, repeating error message -- sound enacting the very compulsion being named.

for us to sense it, and if there's a reason

Repetition-Compulsion Drive (Definition 10.5b.2.18).

I had to repeat

the many violations of my youth

in my thirties, only worse—(make it

more devastating this time,

someone must have chimed in,

some shiftless staff

writer, armchair director)—

Sonic/Formal Note: "Hindsight" sits in close proximity to the image of a hunted deer -- the buried root "hind" (as in hindquarters, what a hunter/predator glimpses of fleeing prey) reactivated by context.

—in hindsight, this was it, wasn't it?

—All this was the gift.—

—They've given me many,

my cleverest hunters,

the men who laid careful traps

as if I were a rare deer,

a delicacy necessary

for the men's survival,

as if my cries ringing out

above birds and brook were not

in fact the downstream consequence

of such men's creature comforts;

Sonic/Formal Note: Ironical gratitude -- sincere-sounding on its surface, not dishonest, but voicing an inverted narrative from inside it (thanking predators for their "gift") so the reader must detect the divergence unassisted, the same mechanism as the van der Kolk passage below.

—I thank those clever hunters,

who gave so much of themselves

to the hunt,

and I thank too what architects

must exist, for their gifts:

Sonic/Formal Note: "Insight" sits immediately before "how the light dies in others' eyes" -- the buried root (in-sight, seeing inward) reactivated by proximity to an image of witnessing, paralleling "hindsight"'s proximity to the fleeing deer below.

a hard-won insight

into how the light dies in others' eyes,

the first time that it went out

in mine.

Cognitive Dissonance (Definition 10.5b.18.4b) and Dissociation Load (10.5b.18.4c) as the restored causal pathway. Siloing (Definition 10.5b.2.22) and Alienation (Definition 10.5b.2.23) -- network-level disconnection and disconnection from consequence, both now formalized alongside the already-present fragmentation and preference falsification.

—But of all their magnificent gifts—the joy

in suffering, the pained burden

of violence—the price of sickness

remains greatest;

because the only way out of a gray plane

of existence—that place of dead space

and pain, of static

interspliced with blood, of towers

Sonic/Formal Note: An unresolved paradox, never resolved elsewhere in the poem -- the speaker must PAY for the "gifts" of suffering ("the price of sickness remains greatest"), holding gift-framing and cost-framing in the same breath without collapsing either.

of ever-teetering tasks,

Sonic/Formal Note: "Of screams that bury us" scans as clean iambic trimeter; "where we expected paradise" as iambic tetrameter -- the exact trimeter/tetrameter alternation of ballad and nursery-rhyme meter ("Mary had a little lamb"). Applied to this content, the effect is more than ironic mismatch: since the poem's subject is trauma carried "since childhood," a childhood-rhythm meter surfacing at the poem's most devastating line reads as the poem's own register briefly reverting to the age the damage occurred at -- the same mechanism that makes "Daddy" devastating. The off-rhyme of "bury us"/"paradise" compounds the unease -- close enough to chime, not close enough to resolve.

of screams that bury us

where we expected paradise,

Ultimate Convergence / Return to the Plane (Definition 10.5b.0.6) -- and its real counterpart, Forced Flattening (Definition 10.5b.0.9a): genuine convergence cannot be forced into being.

the only way out, back to the sunlit

patch of promise into which

Sonic/Formal Note: The rush of enjambment gathering urgency across the preceding lines culminates in "is" ending its own line in isolation, giving it maximal emphasis just before the actual claim ("to nearly die, to be resurrected...") arrives -- a melodramatic, romantic framing of revelation intentionally set up to be deflated by the very next stanza's turn.

we were born, is
to nearly die, to be resurrected, to become
that being of light born of one's own ashes;

Captive Official Layer (Definition 10.5b.18.1) -- genuine blindness, resolved by real illumination reaching it at last. The 360 reset itself (Definition 10.5b.0.6, Ultimate Convergence; Proposition 10.5b.0.3) -- a direct, self-driven exit from the whole high/medium-entropy dichotomy onto the low-entropy baseline, distinct from Forced Permeability Flooding's externally-anchored healing pathway (Definition 10.5b.13.2), which this passage is not describing.

Sonic/Formal Note: The sharpest turn in the poem, marked by an em dash separating it from everything preceding. Unlike "The Next Time"'s turn (an announced discontinuity, formal break and register shift together), this turn deflates rather than announces -- flippant, throwaway-sounding, deliberately undercutting the "phoenix"/rising-from-ashes grandiosity just stated. "But before all that to be" reads as a complete, bare existential claim on its own (before any transformation, the prior need is simply to exist) before the next line specifies what that bare being actually consists of: not myth, but "simply Lazarus" -- restored to ordinary life, not reborn into something new. The flippant tone is not deflecting from seriousness; it is the actual mechanism of relaxation toward minimal verticality (§10.5b.0) that the content describes, form performing the content rather than illustrating it.

—but before all that to be

simply Lazarus, to sink

Sonic/Formal Note: "On our" enjambed at the line break sounds close to "honor," giving two simultaneous readings -- kissing the floor on one's literal knees, and kissing it in honor/reverence. "To sink" (previous line) is the hinge word of the whole turn: held alone at the break it evokes grounding, sinking back into the body, the opposite of dissociative floating -- confirmed by what follows ("cold cave of our embodiment, blind"), where the cave itself is named as a blind, disembodied form of embodiment. The literal continuation (kissing the floor, knees, laughter) earns the grounding reading rather than undercutting it.

to the floor to kiss it, on our

knees to shake

with laughter, and so to exit

the cold cave of

our embodiment, blind;—all the old shapes,

Sonic/Formal Note: Plato's Cave made explicit rather than merely implied -- the entire knocker/knocked, predator/prey framework the poem has been dismantling is named directly as shadow, dispelled the instant real light enters, not defeated through argument or confrontation.

those cave shadows, vanish

in one sun-struck blink

of a bleary eye; and

tears fallen, the light

streams in, as we rush to greet

Sonic/Formal Note: The poem closes on greeting order determined by physical proximity alone, not moral weight -- enemies met first only because they stand closer, with the same passing affection extended to everything in view. The binary has not been defeated; it has stopped being relevant. Note also the closing "we," plausibly doing double work: a royal/collective plural, but also readable as the poem's own previously dissociated parts -- the numb body and the observing mind split throughout the poem -- finally synchronized into one voice at the exact moment of exiting the cave.

our enemies with a kiss

and then our friends.